Middle Grades Redesign
2025 Update



PORTLAND
Public Schools

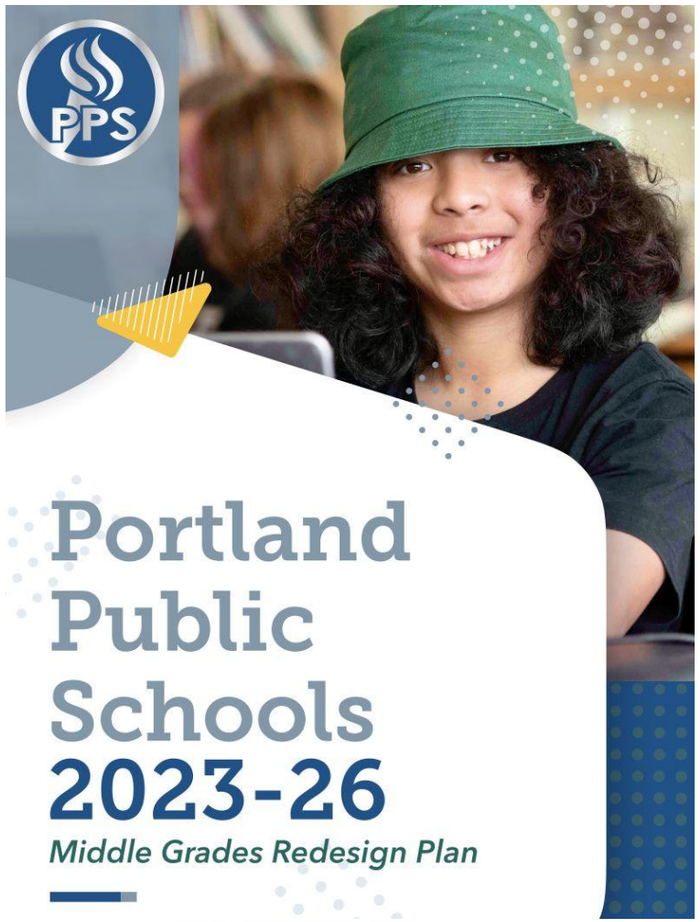
Background

Because the middle grades are a dynamic period for young people, this work prioritizes equitable opportunities for all 6th-8th grade students in the district. Developed collaboratively with the Association for Middle Level Education (AMLE) and incorporating various district and community viewpoints, the plan acknowledges that schools are at different stages of implementing related initiatives.

The plan's eighteen initiatives are organized into five key areas: Inclusive and Differentiated Teaching and Learning, Professional Excellence and Support, Embracing Change, Integrated Adolescent Supports, and Racial Equity and Social Justice.

The implementation of these five areas is supported through District-wide, Simultaneous, and Phased approaches to provide comprehensive support while also recognizing the need for flexibility at each school site.

Consequently, the implementation strategy empowers school leaders to advance the plan, with central support for concurrent district-wide efforts. This plan provides a roadmap for cultivating an empowering, responsive, challenging, equitable, and engaging middle grades experience for every student.



Simultaneous	Year-to-Year	Districtwide
1 | Access to advisory programs	**2** | Extracurricular opportunities	4 | Social-emotional and mental health services
10 | Craft innovative schedules	3 | College and career readiness	5 | Engaging, grade-level, standards-aligned curriculum*
11 | 8th grade field trips and capstone	6 | Project-based learning	9 | Continuous improvement
13 | Restorative Justice framework	7 | Equitable grading and assessment	12 | Culturally-specific and multi-racial organizations
18 | 8th grade success teams	8 | Transitions to middle school	14 | Same-race mentoring and leadership
		15 | Affinity groups
		16 | Planning and collaboration
		17 | Professional learning and support

Directly supported by MGR team Prioritized for 25-26 Collaborative with other departments

Implementation Highlights

2023-2024

8th grade Success Teams
Implemented 8th grade Success Teams in all 28 schools, including collaboration with 9th grade teams for high school transition

Curriculum and Instructional Practices
Increased implementation of district adopted curriculum in grades 6-8

Advisory
All students in grades 6-8 had access to advisory programs

Provide Professional Learning and Support:
Focused on 8th Grade Success Teams, Field Trips/Capstones, and Curriculum Implementation, and School-wide schedule shifts (5 of 7)

2024-2025

Scheduling
Systematized schedules (5 of 7) for grades 6-8, provided professional learning for administrators on best practices

Transitions
Funded training and provided centralized support for 5th to 6th transition, including Jumpstart programming and leadership/mentorship opportunities for 8th graders

Project-Based Learning:
Working group of social studies teachers participated in professional learning to create project-based learning mini units for the 7th and 8th grade curriculum.

Equitable Grading and Assessment:
Foundational work with teachers and leaders in preparation for full implementation during the 2025-26 school year

Middle Grades Field Trips & Capstone

	College and Career Experiences	Bonneville Dam
Field Experience	The Middle Grades Redesign team will partner with local colleges and offer a menu of options for schools to choose from.	Student tour the Bonneville Dam and learn about the societal dependence and environmental impact of dams.
Classroom Learning	This will be linked to Unit 5: Finding Your Path of the Language Arts HMH curriculum, which students will be covering in late March/early April according to the district pacing guide.	This will be linked to Tribal History/Shared History lessons that are required by ODE for 8th graders, specifically around the arguments for dam removal.
Portfolio Product & Capstone	Students will write a personal narrative about an experience that helped them find their path on their journey toward adulthood. This will be incorporated into their website portfolio for student-led conferences and/or a final presentation.	Students will engage in a public debate on dam removal for an authentic audience. Preparation materials and artifacts will be incorporated into their website portfolio for student-led conferences and/or a final presentation.

2024-25 Field Trips

28

SCHOOLS

participating in opportunities offered

13

SITES

hosting Portland Public Schools 7th and 8th graders

100%

8th GRADERS

have the opportunity for an 8th grade trip with at least one of our partners

- Portland Workforce Alliance Career Expo
- INLINE Construction
- Bonneville Lock & Dam
- Hamilton Experience
- Hoyt Arboretum
- Japanese American Museum of Oregon
- Oregon Historical Society
- Oregon Jewish Museum & Center for Holocaust Education*
- Oregon State University
- Oregon Zoo
- University of Oregon
- Portland State University

Middle Grades Capstone

Website Portfolios

- Students build a website portfolio in Google Sites in 6th grade with an "All About Me" page and add a page for each course the student is enrolled in every year of MS
- Artifacts are also uploaded from courses, field trips, college and career exploration lessons, etc.
- Website portfolios are designed to support the capstone experience through student-led conferences
- In 8th grade, students present their website portfolios as their 8th grade capstone

Student websites give students ownership of their learning. This allows students to reflect on what learning is most important, catalogue key assignments and experiences from middle school, and how their middle school experience connects to their long-term goals and journey.

Standards-Based Grading

Full Implementation 2025-26

Currently, the inconsistent use of various grading systems across and within middle schools presents challenges for families in tracking student progress. Transitioning to standards-based grading practices will provide a clearer reflection of student mastery of grade-level standards over time. This shift will ensure all middle school students receive consistent grades that effectively communicate their progress to families and school staff.

This work includes:

- Developing an aligned Synergy grading system for the middle grades.
- Provide guidance and support for school leaders implementing these shifts.
- Providing professional learning for middle grades teachers.
- Aligning all middle grades course offerings to relevant standards.
- Implementing comprehensive family outreach.

Looking Ahead

Key Centrally Supported Focal Areas for 2025-2026

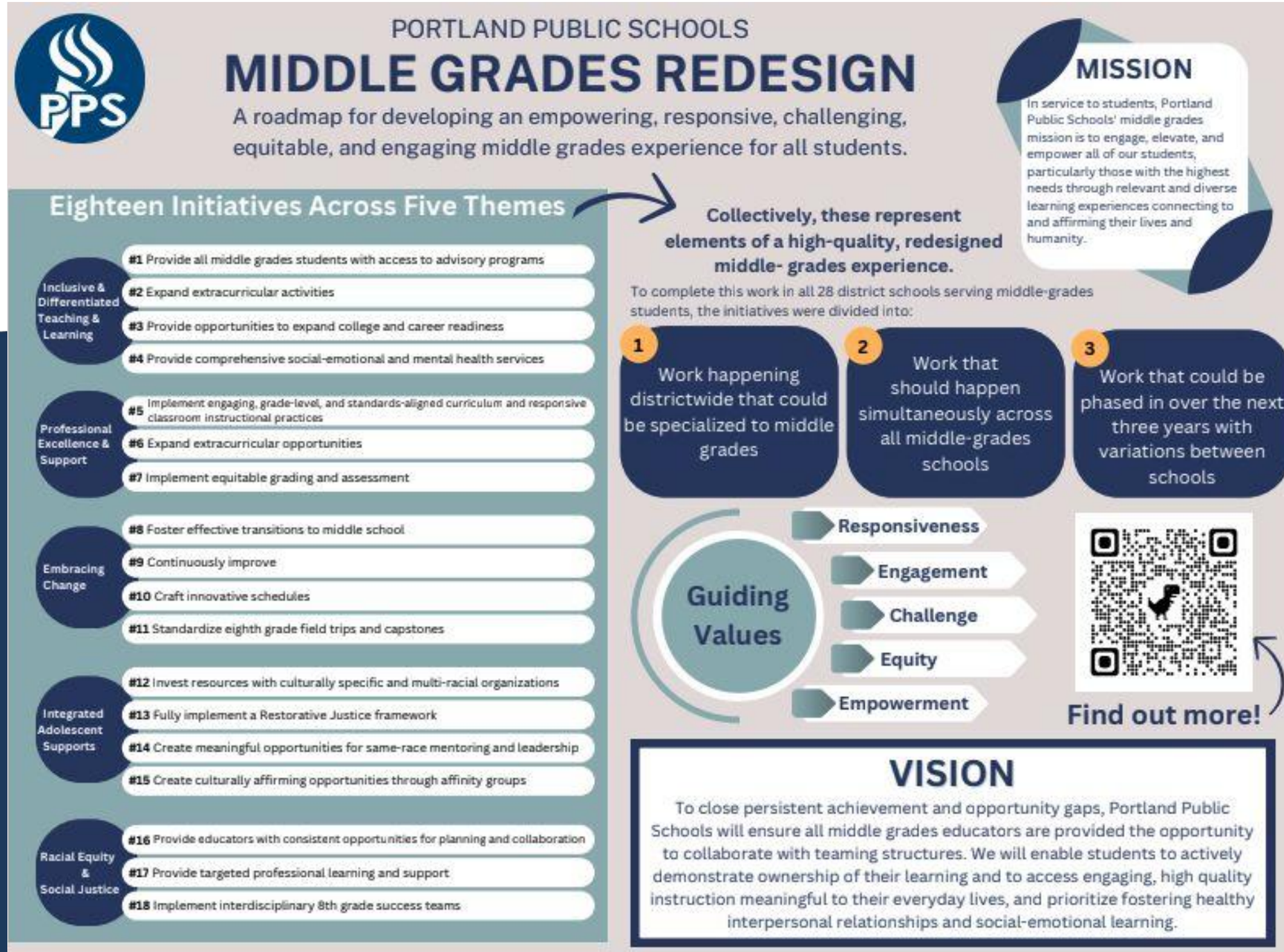
7 | Equitable Grading & Assessment Districtwide implementation of standards-based grading in grades 6-8 (implement fully 2025-26)

8 | Transitions to Middle School Strengthen transition programming for incoming 6th graders and mentorship opportunities for 8th graders

11 | Field Trips & Capstone Expand field trip offerings and capstone portfolio

18 | 8th Grade Success Teams Refine of 8th grade success teams and collaboration with 9th grade success teams to support high school readiness

Resources: Plan Overview and Photos




MIGHTY O OREGON
RICH BROOKS FIELD












AGC






PNCI MISSION STATEMENT






Who Is an Oregonian?
你好
Xin Chào

